



Michelangelo's David

△ Michelangelo (1475–1564), after a self-portrait

One of the masterpieces of the Renaissance or, arguably, of any era, Michelangelo's *David* is exceptional for its lifelike rendering of the male anatomy, vast scale, and unusual treatment of its subject matter. The sculpture represents the biblical David, Israelite slayer of the Philistine giant Goliath. David is carved from solid marble and stands at over 5m (16ft), weighing more than 5 tonnes (5.5 tons). He holds a sling in one hand and a stone in the other. Michelangelo's sculpture is unprecedented in that Goliath is absent and, rather than representing David's victory, shows him poised in the moments before battle. Michelangelo's great achievement is capturing David's pre-battle tension in the protruding veins of



David with Goliath's Head, circle of Caravaggio, c.1600, typically presenting the moment of victory

his hands, the tautness of his neck, and the focus in his gaze – all at monumental scale. Contemporaries were amazed, even though one, Piero Soderini, declared the nose too wide – prompting Michelangelo to make a pretence of altering it, complete with marble dust.

The statue was intended for the battlements of Florence

Cathedral, which may account for the unusually large head and hands, to allow for perspective from below. However, a committee of Florentines, including Leonardo da Vinci and Botticelli, considered the work too exquisite (and heavy) to be displayed there, so it was placed outside the Palazzo della Signoria, the town hall. The position had political significance as the figure of David gazed towards Rome – he was intended to represent Florence, which had recently thrown off the Medici family's rule.

Anyone who has seen Michelangelo's David has no need to see anything else by another sculptor, living or dead

Giorgio Vasari
Painter and artists' biographer, 1511–1574

Key dates

1400–2014

- 1464** Agostino di Duccio is commissioned to create a sculpture of David, and a huge block of marble is provided
- 1400** Authorities plan 12 large Old Testament sculptures for the cathedral buttresses
- 1466** Agostino ceases work for unknown reasons, having started to shape legs, feet, and torso
- 1476** Antonio Rossellino resumes work on the block, but is released from his contract soon after
- 1500** Authorities determine to find a sculptor to finish the statue
- 1500** Michelangelo, aged just 26, wins the contract
- August, 1501** Michelangelo begins work on the sculpture
- September, 1501** Michelangelo begins work on the sculpture
- January, 1504** Committee of Florentines decide not to place completed *David* on the cathedral buttresses
- June, 1504** *David* is moved to the public square of Palazzo della Signoria (Palazzo Vecchio)
- 1800** *David* is moved to Florence's Galleria dell'Accademia to protect it
- 1873** *David* is moved to Florence's Galleria dell'Accademia to protect it
- 1900** A replica is placed on the old site
- 1910** A man damages the toes of the statue's left foot in an attack with a hammer
- 1939–45** The statue is enclosed in bricks to protect it from bombings
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- 2000** The Italian Culture Ministry claims ownership of *David*, which the city of Florence disputes
- 2010** The Italian Culture Ministry claims ownership of *David*, which the city of Florence disputes
- 2014** Concerns arise over micro-fractures in the stump supporting the statue, as well as in the legs



Statue protected by bricks during World War II



Sculpture of *David* as it is today, in Florence